

KEY TOPIC 3: NAZI CONTROL AND DICTATORSHIP

Name:

Class:

Progress & Assessment Tracker

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Do Now	Level	Teacher Comment
Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934	Do Now: / 4		
Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939	Do Now: / 4		
Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939	Do Now: / 4		
Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939	Do Now: / 4		
Final Unit Grade:			

Key Topic 3.1: The Creation of a Dictatorship, 1933–1934

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise chronological knowledge of the rapid steps Hitler took to secure power between January 1933 and August 1934.
- ☐ Analyse how Hitler used the Reichstag Fire and the Enabling Act to legally destroy political opposition and civil liberties.
- ☐ Evaluate the significance of the Night of the Long Knives and the Army Oath in eliminating internal threats and securing absolute power as Führer.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. On what exact date did Paul von Hindenburg appoint Adolf Hitler as Chancellor of Germany?

2. What is meant by the historical term 'backstairs intrigue'?

3. How many Nazis were actually allowed in Hitler's very first Cabinet in January 1933?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why Franz von Papen believed he could control Hitler in 1933.

When Hitler became Chancellor in January 1933, his power was extremely limited. Germany was still a democracy, he did not have a majority in the Reichstag, and President Hindenburg could sack him at any time. Hitler immediately called an election for March 1933, hoping to secure a clear majority.

Six days before the election, on **27 February 1933**, the Reichstag building was burned to the ground. A young Dutch communist, **Marinus van der Lubbe**, was caught at the scene with matches and firelighters. Hitler claimed this was the signal for a violent communist takeover of Germany.

Hitler manipulated this crisis perfectly. He convinced President Hindenburg to declare a state of emergency and sign the **Decree for the Protection of the People and the State**. This decree legally suspended civil rights—freedom of speech, freedom of the press, and the right to assemble were instantly gone. Using this terrifying new power, Hermann Göring's police arrested 4,000 communist leaders and shut down all opposition newspapers, severely weakening Nazi opponents right before the election.

Despite the violence and intimidation, the Nazis still only won 288 seats (44%) in the March 1933 election—not the two-thirds majority needed to change the constitution.

To gain absolute power legally, Hitler proposed the **Enabling Act**. This law would give him the right to pass laws without the Reichstag for four years. To get the required two-thirds vote, Hitler used his emergency powers to ban the 81 Communist politicians from entering the building.

Hitler still needed more votes, so he struck a deal with the Catholic Centre Party, falsely promising to protect the Catholic Church if they voted for him. Meanwhile, the SA surrounded the Kroll Opera House (where the parliament was temporarily meeting), chanting, 'Give us the

bill or else fire and murder!' The remaining politicians were terrified. The Enabling Act passed by a massive margin of 444 votes to 94. **Democracy in Germany was officially dead.** The Reichstag had essentially voted itself out of existence.

Armed with the Enabling Act, Hitler began the rapid process of ***Gleichschaltung***—bringing all of German society into line. He systematically destroyed all external opposition:

May 1933 (Trade Unions): *Trade unions were banned, their leaders arrested, and their funds confiscated. Workers were forced into the Nazi-run German Labour Front (DAF). This meant workers could no longer strike against the government.*

July 1933 (Political Parties): Hitler passed the *Law Against the Formation of Parties*. All political parties except the NSDAP were officially banned. Germany was now a one-party state.

January 1934 (Local Government): *The 18 regional state governments (Länder*) were stripped of their power, and highly loyal Nazi governors were appointed to run every region directly from Berlin.*

By 1934, Hitler's only remaining threat was internal: **Ernst Röhm and the SA.**

The SA had grown to over 3 million men and was intensely loyal to Röhm rather than Hitler. Röhm wanted a 'second revolution' to make Germany more socialist, and he wanted to merge his SA with the regular German army (*Reichswehr*).

The regular army generals and wealthy industrialists despised Röhm. They warned Hitler that if the SA was not stopped, the army would step in and remove Hitler from power. Hitler knew he needed the army to survive. To justify action, Heinrich Himmler and Reinhard Heydrich fabricated evidence that Röhm was planning a treasonous uprising (the 'Röhm Putsch').

On **30 June 1934**, Hitler launched the **Night of the Long Knives**. The SS arrested Röhm and hundreds of SA leaders, dragging them from their beds. Röhm was later shot in his cell.

Hitler used this violent purge not just to crush the SA, but to murder old enemies and settle scores. **Gregor Strasser**, a prominent left-wing Nazi rival, was assassinated. Former Chancellor **Kurt von Schleicher** (who had tried to split the Nazis in 1932) was shot dead alongside his wife. **Gustav von Kahr** (who had betrayed Hitler during the 1923 Munich Putsch) was hacked to death in a swamp. Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen was put under house arrest, permanently terrifying him into silence. Approximately 400 people were murdered. Days later, Hitler passed a law making the murders legal, proving that he was now above the law itself.

On **2 August 1934**, President Hindenburg died at the age of 86. Within hours, Hitler declared himself **Führer** (Supreme Leader), officially combining the roles of Chancellor and President.

On the exact same day, the entire German army swore a new **Oath of Allegiance**. Crucially, they did not swear to protect Germany or the constitution; they swore unconditional obedience to the

person of *Adolf Hitler*. To cement this, Hitler held a public plebiscite (referendum) in mid-August; 90% of German voters agreed with his new powers. With the army firmly on his side, and the SA broken, Hitler's totalitarian dictatorship was complete.

Documentary / General Notes

Title / Topic: _____

☐ Emerging (1-2) ☐ Emerging+ (3) ☐ Expected (4-5) ☐ Expected+ (6-7) ☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Key Topic 3.2: The Police State and Religion, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different, overlapping branches of the Nazi police state, distinguishing between the roles of the SS, SD, and Gestapo.
- ☐ Analyse how the Nazis completely removed the independence of the German legal system to ensure the courts always ruled in Hitler's favour.
- ☐ Evaluate the varying successes and failures of Nazi policies towards the Catholic and Protestant churches.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the law passed in March 1933 that effectively allowed Hitler to rule Germany as a dictator for four years?

2. What is meant by the historical term Gleichschaltung?

3. On what exact date did Hitler launch the Night of the Long Knives?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about why Hitler felt he had to murder Ernst Röhm.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Vocabulary Mapping

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

SS (Schutzstaffel) | SD (Sicherheitsdienst) | Gestapo | Schutzhaft (Protective Custody) | The Concordat (1933) | Reich Church | Confessional Church

Your Sentence:

1. The Machinery of Terror: SS, SD, and Gestapo To maintain absolute control, Hitler could not rely on the regular German police forces, which were run by local governments. Instead, he built a terrifying, highly organised 'Police State' directly loyal to the Nazi Party, operating completely outside normal laws. * **The SS:** Led by **Heinrich Himmler**, the SS grew from a small bodyguard unit into a massive organisation of deeply loyal, racially "pure" Aryans. By 1936, Himmler was placed in charge of all police forces in Germany. The ruthless 'Death's Head Units' of the SS were responsible for running the concentration camps. * **The SD:** Formed in 1931 by Himmler and run by his ruthless deputy, **Reinhard Heydrich**, the SD was the intelligence-gathering wing of the party. They kept a massive card index of anyone suspected of opposing the Nazis, spying on everyone from high-ranking politicians to ordinary citizens. * **The Gestapo:**

Also commanded by Heydrich, the Gestapo was the non-uniformed Secret State Police. They had the power to tap telephones, open mail, and use **Schutzhaft (Protective Custody)** to arrest people and send them straight to concentration camps without a trial.

Advanced Analysis: The RSHA and the 'Myth' of the Gestapo By 1939, Himmler consolidated all these overlapping branches (Gestapo, SD, and criminal police) into a single monstrous umbrella organisation: the **RSHA (Reich Main Security Office)**, overseen by Heydrich. Yet, Nazi propaganda deliberately created the terrifying myth that the Gestapo itself was an enormous, all-seeing organisation with agents on every street corner. In reality, the Gestapo was surprisingly small; in 1939, a major city like Frankfurt only had 28 Gestapo agents for a population of nearly half a million. The true horror of the police state was that it relied on **ordinary citizens**. Roughly 80% of all Gestapo arrests were triggered by voluntary denunciations—neighbours, local block wardens ('Blockleiters'), and even children reporting on each other out of spite, jealousy, or brainwashed loyalty.

2. Controlling the Legal System Hitler knew that his police state would only work if the courts supported it. He systematically destroyed the independence of the German legal system: * **The Judges:** All judges were forced to join the **National Socialist League for the Maintenance of the Law**. If a judge did not rule the way the Nazi Party wanted, they were instantly sacked. * **The People's Court:** In 1934, Hitler set up the People's Court ('Volksgerichtshof') to try cases of treason. Juries were abolished. Instead, cases were heard by fanatical Nazi judges, most notoriously the screaming, aggressive **Roland Freisler**. Trials were held in secret, there was no right to appeal, and the number of death penalties skyrocketed.

3. The Early Concentration Camps The ultimate weapon of the police state was the concentration camp. The first camp, **Dachau**, was opened in 1933. In this early period (1933–39), these were primarily 'political' prisons, not the extermination camps they would later become. Inmates were mostly communists, trade unionists, outspoken journalists, and political rivals. They were used as forced labour, subjected to brutal beatings by SS guards, and deliberately kept in terrible conditions to serve as a terrifying warning to the rest of the population.

4. Controlling the Churches: The Catholic Concordat Religion was a massive threat to Hitler. Christianity preached peace, forgiveness, and loyalty to God over any earthly leader. In 1933, one-third of Germans were Catholic, and two-thirds were Protestant. Initially, Hitler tried to compromise with the Catholic Church. In **July 1933**, he signed the **Concordat** with the Pope. The Pope agreed that Catholic priests would stay out of German politics, and in return, Hitler promised not to interfere with Catholic schools or youth groups. However, Hitler quickly broke this treaty. By 1935, he had set up a dedicated **Ministry of Church Affairs** under **Hanns Kerrl** to systematically weaken religious power. In 1936, the state aggressively campaigned to remove crucifixes from Catholic classrooms, Catholic schools were forcibly closed, and the Catholic Youth League was banned. In 1937, a furious [Key Individual: Pope Pius XI issued a scorching public letter called *Mit brennender Sorge* '(With Burning Concern)'. It was secretly smuggled into Germany and read out in every Catholic church, openly condemning Hitler's broken promises and his dangerous "myth of race and blood."

5. Controlling the Churches: The Protestants The Protestant churches were heavily divided. Hitler united the pro-Nazi Protestants into a single **Reich Church**, led by **Ludwig Müller** (the 'Reich Bishop'). Its members called themselves 'German Christians'. They wore Nazi uniforms, hung swastikas inside their churches, and demanded that the Old Testament of the Bible be banned because of its Jewish origins. In disgust, a brave First World War U-boat commander turned pastor named **Martin Niemöller** set up the **Pastors' Emergency League (PEL)**, which evolved into the rival **Confessional Church** in 1934. Over 6,000 Protestant pastors joined Niemöller, alongside theologians like [Key Individual: **Dietrich Bonhoeffer** (who secretly trained illegal pastors), in preaching against Nazi interference in religion. The Nazis responded with brutal force: Niemöller was arrested in 1937 and eventually sent to Sachsenhausen concentration camp, and hundreds of his pastors were imprisoned.

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Documentary / General Notes

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Teacher Comment:

Key Topic 3.3: Controlling and Influencing Attitudes, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the methods Goebbels used to censor the press, literature, and radio.
- ☐ Analyse how the Nazis utilised mass rallies, the 1936 Berlin Olympics, and cheap technology (like the Volksempfänger) as tools of indoctrination.
- ☐ Evaluate the ways in which the Nazis crushed independent thought by controlling art, architecture, and music through the Reich Chamber of Culture.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the government department set up in 1935 to weaken the power of Christianity?

2. What is meant by the German term Schutzhaft (Protective Custody)?

3. Who was the brutal judge placed in charge of the People's Court?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about the difference between the SS, the SD, and the Gestapo.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Mini-Frayer Model

Complete the Frayer Model for the term: **Censorship**

Definition	Historical Example
Non-Example / Sketch	Your own sentence

1. Goebbels and the Ministry of Propaganda In March 1933, Hitler appointed **Joseph Goebbels** as the Minister of Public Enlightenment and Propaganda. Goebbels was a mastermind of psychological manipulation. He understood that for propaganda to work, it had to be inescapable but often subtle. His goal was the 'Gleichschaltung' (coordination) of the German mind—ensuring that every time a citizen opened a newspaper, turned on the radio, or went to the cinema, they absorbed the Nazi message.

2. Censorship: Crushing the Truth Goebbels systematically destroyed free speech in Germany to ensure no one could hear anti-Nazi viewpoints: **The Press:** *In October 1933, Goebbels passed the **Schriftleitergesetz*** (Editor's Law),* making newspaper editors legally responsible for what was printed, effectively forcing them to censor themselves. Furthermore, the official Nazi publishing house, the **Eher Verlag**, systematically bought up independent newspapers. By 1939, the Nazis directly owned or controlled 82% of all newspapers in Germany. * **Literature:** In May 1933, Goebbels organised massive "Book Burnings" across Germany. Brainwashed university students threw over 20,000 books written by Jews, communists, and pacifists (like Albert Einstein and Karl Marx) into massive bonfires in Berlin.

3. Propaganda: Mass Rallies and the Radio Having silenced the opposition, Goebbels flooded Germany with Nazi ideology: **The Radio:** *Goebbels realised that hearing Hitler's charismatic voice was the most effective way to brainwash the public. He subsidised the mass production of the **Volksempfänger*** (People's Receiver).* These radios were deliberately designed with a short range so they could not pick up foreign stations like the BBC. By 1939, over 70% of German homes owned one. Crucially, listening was enforced: loudspeakers were erected in streets and factories, and sirens would sound to halt all work when Hitler made a major speech. * **Mass Rallies:** Every September, the Nazis held a massive rally in Nuremberg. These were carefully choreographed theatrical spectacles. **Albert Speer**, Hitler's favourite architect, designed the 'Cathedral of Light' using 130 anti-aircraft searchlights pointing into the night sky,

creating a semi-religious, overwhelming atmosphere of power and unity. * **Film:** Cinemas were immensely popular. Goebbels commissioned director **Leni Riefenstahl** to make 'Triumph of the Will' (documenting the 1934 Nuremberg Rally), which is still studied today as a masterpiece of propaganda. However, 80% of Nazi films were actually comedies or dramas that just had subtle anti-Semitic or pro-Aryan messages woven into the plot.

4. The 1936 Berlin Olympics The 1936 Olympic Games provided Hitler with the ultimate global stage to showcase the "superiority" of the Aryan race and the efficiency of the Nazi state. * **The Deception:** Goebbels carefully paused the regime's brutality. Violent anti-Semitic newspapers like 'Der Stürmer' were temporarily removed from newsstands, and "Jews Not Wanted" signs were taken down. Foreign visitors left genuinely impressed by the clean, prosperous, and highly organised "New Germany". * **The International Failure vs. Domestic Success:** Hitler's primary goal was to prove Aryan racial supremacy. Internationally, this was undermined by the African-American athlete **Jesse Owens**, who won four gold medals. However, for the domestic German audience, the propaganda was a massive triumph: Germany dominated the overall medal table, winning 33 gold medals (far ahead of America's 24), which Goebbels used as 'proof' of Aryan superiority.

5. Controlling Culture and the Arts Hitler fancied himself an artist, and he believed that culture should reflect the heroic, traditional values of the German race. In September 1933, the **Reich Chamber of Culture** was set up. If you wanted to publish a book, sell a painting, or play in an orchestra, you 'had' to be a member. Jews and political opponents were banned. **Art:** *Modern, abstract art was despised by Hitler and banned as Entartete Kunst** (Degenerate Art). In 1937, the Nazis held a massive 'Degenerate Art Exhibition' in Munich, where banned paintings were hung crookedly and surrounded by insulting graffiti to encourage the public to mock them. Instead, the Nazis promoted heroic, realistic paintings of muscular Aryan soldiers and fertile peasant women. * **Architecture:** Hitler favoured monumental, neoclassical architecture (huge stone buildings with classical pillars). Albert Speer designed buildings that were deliberately massive to make the individual feel small and the State feel eternal. * **Music:** Jewish composers (like Mendelssohn) were completely banned. American Jazz was outlawed because it was seen as "black music". Instead, Germans were encouraged to listen to traditional German composers like **Richard Wagner** and Beethoven.

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Teacher Comment:

Key Topic 3.4: Opposition, Resistance and Conformity, 1933–1939

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Demonstrate precise knowledge of the different youth opposition groups, distinguishing between the working-class Edelweiss Pirates and the middle-class Swing Youth.
- ☐ Analyse the methods used by underground political networks, industrial workers, and lone-wolf attackers to resist the Nazi state.
- ☐ Evaluate the reasons why the vast majority of the German population conformed to Nazi rule rather than actively opposing it.

Do Now Activity

Score: / 4

1. What was the name of the Nazi publishing house that bought up 82% of all German newspapers by 1939?

2. What is meant by the Nazi term Entartete Kunst?

3. How many gold medals did Germany win at the 1936 Berlin Olympics?

4. 15 Second Challenge: Try to speak for 15 seconds non-stop about how Joseph Goebbels used radio to brainwash the German public.

Vocabulary Check

Style: Contextual Cloze

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Conformity | Passive Resistance | Active Resistance | Sopade Reports | Sabotage
| Edelweiss Pirates | Swing Youth

1. The Illusion of Total Support: Why did most people conform? Looking back, it is easy to ask why millions of Germans didn't rise up against Hitler. The reality is that active opposition was incredibly dangerous. Most Germans conformed for two main reasons: * **Genuine Support:** By 1939, Hitler was genuinely popular with many Germans. He had smashed the hated Treaty of Versailles, rebuilt the army, and seemingly created an 'economic miracle' by drastically reducing unemployment. Many were willing to turn a blind eye to the brutality of the police state because they felt the Nazis were restoring national pride. * **Fear and the Scale of Repression:** The Gestapo and the block wardens terrified people into submission. Between 1933 and 1939, approximately **1.3 million Germans** were sent to concentration camps for political offenses, and another 300,000 fled the country entirely.

2. Underground Political and Worker Resistance When Hitler banned all rival political parties in 1933, opposition was forced underground. * **The SPD and the 'Sopade':** The Social Democratic Party leadership fled into exile. From abroad, they relied on a secret network of informants inside Germany to write the **Sopade reports**. These intelligence reports detailed the true mood of the working classes, proving that not everyone was completely brainwashed by Goebbels' propaganda. * **The Communists (KPD) and Workers:** The KPD continued to secretly print anti-Nazi leaflets. Furthermore, because Trade Unions were banned, industrial workers resisted in more subtle ways. They engaged in **passive resistance** and **sabotage**: deliberately working slowly ('slow-working'), calling in sick (absenteeism), or secretly damaging factory machinery to disrupt the Nazi economy. In 1936, there were even lightning strikes over high food prices.

Advanced Analysis: Lone-Wolf, Army, and Religious Resistance Not all resistance came from underground groups; some of the most dangerous opposition came from individuals and elites: * **The Lone Wolf:** In November 1939, a communist-sympathising carpenter named **Georg Elser** planted a sophisticated time bomb inside a Munich Beer Hall where Hitler was speaking. It detonated flawlessly, killing eight people, but Hitler had unexpectedly left the building just 13 minutes earlier. Elser was caught and executed in Dachau. * **Elite Army Discontent:** Not all generals supported Hitler. In 1938, **General Ludwig Beck**, the Chief of Staff of the German Army, actively plotted to overthrow Hitler and resigned his post in protest against Hitler's

aggressive foreign policy, which he feared would cause another world war. * **Religious Martyrs:** Linking back to the church opposition, **Pastor Paul Schneider** actively smuggled anti-Nazi letters out of his prison cell and refused to salute the swastika. Known as the "Preacher of Buchenwald," he was tortured and murdered by the SS in 1939.

3. Youth Opposition: The Edelweiss Pirates The Hitler Youth became compulsory in 1936. While many enjoyed it initially, as it became increasingly strict, militaristic, and focused on endless drilling, a counter-culture emerged. The **Edelweiss Pirates** emerged in the late 1930s (made up of local groups like the 'Navajos' in Cologne, or the 'Roving Dudes' in Essen). They were primarily **working-class** teenagers. They rebelled by: * Wearing their hair long and dressing in American-style checked shirts and white socks. * Going on weekend hikes in the countryside to escape the suffocating control of the Nazi block wardens. * Singing banned songs (often changing the lyrics of Hitler Youth songs to mock the regime). * Taunting, ambushing, and physically beating up Hitler Youth patrols.

4. Youth Opposition: The Swing Youth While the Pirates were working-class, the **Swing Youth** were largely **middle and upper-class** teenagers in big cities like Berlin and Hamburg. They had the wealth to own record players and rebelled culturally rather than violently. * They illegally listened to banned American Jazz and Swing music (such as Glenn Miller), which the Nazis despised as "black" and "Jewish" music. * They dressed in sharp 'English' styles—boys carried umbrellas and wore tailored suits, while girls wore makeup (which the Nazis banned, as they wanted women to have a natural, 'peasant' look). * They organised illegal underground dances, attended by thousands, where they jitterbugged and smoked.

5. The Nazi Reaction to Youth Opposition Before the outbreak of war in 1939, the Nazi response to these youth groups was relatively lenient. The Gestapo would occasionally break up Swing Youth dances, confiscate record players, or arrest Edelweiss Pirates, shave their heads, and give them a severe beating before releasing them. The Nazis did not want to send thousands of young, healthy Aryans to concentration camps. '(Note: This would change drastically during WWII, when youth opposition became more political and the Nazi punishments became lethal).'

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